



PACKING A PUNCH:
Coach Jagdish Singh
with his trainees at
Bhiwani

Photographs by VIKRAM SHARMA

NO OTHER SPORT, NOT EVEN CRICKET, FIRES THE IMAGINATION OF BHIWANI'S BOYS. ON AVERAGE THERE ARE 1,000 BOYS TRAINING AT ITS MANY COACHING CENTRES.

fires the imagination of Bhiwani's boys. On any given day, there are around 1,000 boys training at the Sports Authority of India (SAI)-run centre and half a dozen private coaching institutes that attract aspirants from the surrounding countryside.

The credit for turning Bhiwani into an elite boxing centre largely goes to an intrepid SAI coach Jagdish Singh, who has been at the centre since 1996. A former national boxer, Jagdish has "produced boxers like a factory", says his boss and SAI (North Zone) Director S.S. Roy. Using his eye for talent and unconventional training methods, Jagdish has built a formidable centre and a reputation for himself. "I made a clean break from the 'we-know-all' at-

titude of most coaches," he says, alert to the importance of updating his own learning. On overseas trips, Jagdish acquired videos of boxing champions and assessed them, filming the best bouts of the top boxers in whichever event he was at. He met the legendary Hungarian boxer László Papp, who won gold medals in three successive Olympics, and tracked down his videos as part of his study into the 'sweet science'.

De-constructing international fights, Jagdish says has helped his Indians fighters refine their tactics and also gain confidence. Between them, Jagdish reckons, his trainees have won 161 international and 312 national medals. Roy tries to explain the coach's obsession with boxing: "One has to be

either super motivated or just mad." Local advocate Joginder Singh, whose 14-year-old-nephew has recently joined the boxing academy, jokes that it is unlikely Jagdish would know which class his own children are studying in.

In last eight years, the number of aspirant fighters in Bhiwani has increased more than 10-fold. The SAI centre has doubled its intake, with boxing forming major component of its 135-odd trainees. Private academies have mushroomed too and SAI coach Dev Raj says, "Fierce competition between the local coaches and training academies has led to making Bhiwani a centre of boxing excellence."

Local boxing centres enroll the boys between 10 and 14 years of age, who are expected to perform at national